

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN MADAGASCAR

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action decides project outcomes in Madagascar, and one small farming town proved it against a foreign gold company. In 2016, the people of **Soamahamanina** — a commune of some fourteen thousand west of the capital — learned that a Chinese firm, **Jiuxing Mines**, had been handed a forty-year license to mine gold across seventy-five hundred hectares of their land, the rice fields and hills their families had farmed and been buried in for generations. They did not accept it. Week after week, every Thursday, they marched. When security forces met them with tear gas and arrested their leaders, they kept marching, and the arrests only drew national attention and a United Nations human-rights rapporteur. By July the **government had halted the project**, and by October the company announced it would pull out; the Chinese management left Soamahamanina, abandoning their tents. A farming community with nothing but its unity and its refusal had driven out a foreign mining company and forced its own government to stop the mine. Three years later, the same lever worked again: in 2019, citing "opposition from local communities," the government **suspended the Base Toliara mineral-sands mine** in the southwest. Base Toliara — an ilmenite and mineral-sands project run by an Australian company, forecast to produce hundreds of thousands of tonnes a year — rested on a license issued in 2012 by a transitional government that had itself come to power in a 2009 coup, a provenance that left its legitimacy open to question. When the government suspended it in November 2019, it cited both the opposition of local communities and terms unfavourable to the people and the state. Civil society hailed the decision as putting people above a private company, and hoped it would set a precedent — though, as this guide will stress, the company did not accept it and fought to revive the project. In Madagascar, a community that will not be moved can move even the powerful. The Soamahamanina story is worth telling in full, because its details are the lessons. The town sits in the Itasy region, some seventy kilometres west of Antananarivo; the license Jiuxing Mines had obtained ran for forty years over gold, zinc, lead, and beryllium; and to a community of rice farmers, the prospect was the ruin of the fields and hills their ancestors had worked and were buried in. The protests were not a single outburst but a discipline: every Thursday, for months, the townspeople gathered and marched. When five of them, including their leaders, were arrested after security forces used tear gas, the arrests did not break the movement — they brought a United Nations human-rights rapporteur and the eyes of the country, and the five were eventually freed. The company, its investment already sunk, chose to leave rather than face an unending confrontation.

The Soamahamanina fight teaches two things about winning in Madagascar — including its hard limits, which this guide will not hide. The first is the pattern: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected community, the ancestral-land attachment, the wider public, the sacred-site and biodiversity arguments, the courts, the international allies, and the media — pressed together until the project was halted. The second is distinctly Malagasy. The decisive lever here is **sustained community protest**, rooted in something deeper than economics: the profound Malagasy attachment to **ancestral land, the tanindrazana**, and to the tombs of the ancestors, so that a threat to the land is a threat to identity and the sacred. That, together with the **fady** — the taboos that protect certain forests, hills, and sites — and Madagascar's **globally unique biodiversity**, which gives a threatened forest a worldwide constituency, gives communities here real and distinctive power.

But the same story carries honest warnings, and this guide states them plainly and without softening, because in Madagascar they are severe. This is one of the poorest countries on Earth, and a company's promise of **jobs and money is the sharpest weapon against a community** — it divides desperate people, and a family with nothing may see a mine as hope, not threat. This is the hardest truth in any Malagasy campaign, and it must be faced squarely rather than wished away. A company arriving in a desperately poor rural area with offers of wages, cash payments, boreholes, or a new school is not making an empty gesture; to some families it is offering the first real money they have seen, and their hope is genuine and understandable. A campaign that treats such neighbours as traitors will fracture; one that acknowledges the need honestly, while making the case that the money is fleeting and the land eternal, has a chance of holding the community together — which is the whole game. The **state is weak, unstable, and often captured** — licenses have been granted by coup governments and questioned later, corruption is real, and the rule of law is thin. **Defenders are arrested, gassed, and detained**, as the villagers of Soamahamanina and, later, the "Toliara nine" were. And wins are often **suspensions, not cancellations** — Base Toliara was suspended, then fought to revive itself, and a giant mineral-sands mine run by a global company has operated near Fort Dauphin for years despite opposition. That mine, run by a subsidiary of one of the world's largest mining companies at Fort Dauphin in the southeast, has faced years of local complaint over a breached buffer, water, and livelihoods, and won concessions and compensation commitments —

but it was not stopped, and it operates still. It is the honest counterweight to Soamahamanina: where a project is large, backed by a global major, and entangled with the state, a community may extract improvements and compensation but not a halt, and a campaign should know from the outset which kind of fight it is in. This guide is written with both truths in view: the real, distinctive power of a united Malagasy community, and the poverty, repression, and instability it must overcome.

Most communities do not know HOW to make opposition effective. They worry, assume "the government and the company have decided," and never turn their fear into organised, sustained protest. They never invoke the ancestral land or the sacred sites, never reach the national public or the international allies, never use the courts, never build the unity that resists the promise of money. They generate private anger without a public campaign. The gap between a community that stops a project and one that watches it get built is rarely courage or numbers. It is method — and, above all in Madagascar, unity.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Malagasy system as it is.

The Strategic Framework

Effective opposition campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whichever project they face:

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STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION (find the decision and its weak point)
STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION         (build proof of harm and of every defect)
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION      (build unity and sustain the protest)
STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES      (the mining code, the permit, and the courts)
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY        (make the fight national and international)
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These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. Documentation feeds the legal case and the public argument at once; the sustained protest is the pressure decision-makers respond to; a court filing or an international appeal is a headline and a headline strengthens the protest. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that wins. The Soamahamanina campaign did exactly this — it documented the threat to the land, sustained the weekly protest, drew national and international attention, and held its unity against every inducement, until the government halted the mine and the company left.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Madagascar's give communities a distinctive set:

- **Sustained community protest.** Organised, disciplined, week-after-week protest is Madagascar's decisive lever — the force that drove a gold company out of Soamahamanina and suspended a mine at Toliara. What makes it work is not size alone but discipline and endurance: a protest that is peaceful, regular, and rooted in an argument the wider nation accepts — the defence of ancestral land — is one the government finds hard to dismiss as disorder and hard to crush without cost. The weekly rhythm of Soamahamanina mattered as much as the numbers, because it showed a resolve that would not fade, and made clear to the company that the confrontation would not end until it did.
- **Ancestral land and the tombs.** The Malagasy attachment to the **tanindrazana** — ancestral land — and to the tombs of the ancestors makes a threat to the land a threat to identity and the sacred, and roots a resistance that money cannot easily buy.
- **The fady and sacred sites.** The system of **fady** — taboos protecting certain forests, hills, lakes, and sites — gives some places a cultural protection a community can invoke. A forest that is fady, a sacred hill, a lake where certain acts are forbidden — these carry a weight in Malagasy life that no permit overrides in the eyes of the community, and invoking them frames a project not merely as harmful but as a violation of the sacred order. Where a project touches such a place, the fady is both a genuine reason for opposition and a powerful way to root the community's resistance in something older and deeper than any mining law.
- **Globally unique biodiversity.** Madagascar's extraordinary endemism — the lemurs, the baobabs, the forests found nowhere else — gives a threatened habitat a worldwide constituency and powerful international allies.
- **National attention and international allies.** A local fight can become a national cause and draw the world's conservation and human-rights networks, whose scrutiny reaches investors and governments.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers overcome every obstacle, and in Madagascar the obstacles are grave.

Poverty and the promise of money divide communities, and are the proponent's sharpest weapon. The **state is weak, unstable, and often captured**, and cannot be relied on to enforce the law or resist a powerful company. **Defenders**

face arrest and repression. And wins are often **suspensions that must be defended**, not permanent cancellations. This guide takes those limits seriously, names them plainly, and shows you how to fight anyway — building the unity that resists the money, rooting the fight in the ancestral land, drawing national and international allies, and pursuing the halt, the suspension, the delay, and the record that are often what progress actually looks like.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single weekend, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the decision is weakest.

The Levels of Decision

A Malagasy development project runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene.

The mining or project license. Mining turns on a **license** granted centrally, through the mining administration (the registry, the BCMM) and the government — the level at which Soamahamanina's and Base Toliara's licenses were granted, and questioned.

The environmental permit. Significant projects need an **environmental permit** and impact study, administered by the **National Environment Office (ONE)**, in principle with public consultation — a formal point of scrutiny, though enforcement is weak.

The land and the ancestral claim. Much land is held under **customary and ancestral tenure**, and the attachment to the **tanindrazana** and the tombs is both a legal and a profound moral claim against a project.

The local and regional authorities. Communes, mayors, and regional authorities have roles — though they are often courted or captured by a project, so treat them as contested, not automatically allied.

The national government and the courts. The **central government** grants and can suspend licenses, as it halted Soamahamanina and suspended Base Toliara, and the **courts** can, in principle, review legality — both reachable above all by public and political pressure. This is worth grasping clearly, because it shapes the whole strategy: in Madagascar the formal institutions — the licensing office, the environment office, the local authorities, even the courts — are often too weak or too compromised to be relied upon on their own, so the decisive decisions to halt or suspend a project have tended to come from the central government responding to pressure it cannot ignore. That means the real target of a Malagasy campaign is frequently not a courtroom or a permit hearing but the political calculation of a government weighing the cost of a united community and the world's attention against the benefit of a single mine.

The Journey of a Project

A typical project moves from a license, through an **environmental permit and study**, onto **land held under ancestral and customary claim**, past **local authorities**, into **the courts** if challenged, with **community protest** running powerfully alongside — and, for the decision to halt or suspend, up to the **national government**, before construction.

Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in. The earliest doors are the cheapest and widest: the protest, the ancestral-land claim, documentation, and the sacred-site and biodiversity arguments. The later doors — a court challenge, an international appeal, a government suspension — are more demanding but real, and Soamahamanina was halted through sustained protest and national attention. Find out exactly where your project stands on this path; that tells you which door is open now.

Follow the License, the Land, and the Money

Behind the project stand a proponent — a foreign mining company, often Chinese, Australian, or a global major — its financiers and buyers, and the officials who granted the license. Trace who owns and funds the proponent, who profits, who authorised it, and — critically in Madagascar — **whether the license is sound or was granted irregularly**, as by a coup government, and **what the project does to the ancestral land, the farms, the water, the sacred sites, and the unique habitat**. Two questions unlock most Malagasy fights: **What does it do to the ancestral land, the farms, and the sacred and unique places?** and **Is the license and permit sound, or granted irregularly, and can the community stay united against the money?** The threat to the land and the unity of the community are, together, the heart of most Malagasy campaigns. The two are bound together: the threat to the ancestral land is what gives the community a reason to unite, and the unity is what turns that reason into a force. A campaign that documents the harm but cannot hold the community together will watch its case dissolve as the money spreads; one that holds together but cannot articulate what is being lost will struggle to reach the nation and the world. Build both from the first day — the

argument about the land and the unity it inspires — and let each strengthen the other.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies that watch the deciders, because they are levers too. The **courts** can review legality; the **National Environment Office** oversees the permit; the **national government** can halt or suspend; the **international conservation and human-rights networks** watch over Madagascar's unique nature and its defenders; and the **national public and the press** watch throughout — the ultimate overseers who, over Soamahamanina, forced a halt and a withdrawal. In a weak state, the **sustained public protest and the international networks** are the two levers that most reliably move a project, because the domestic institutions are often captured or powerless. Each is a separate front, and a project that threatens the ancestral land, offends the law, and faces a united public and the world's scrutiny rarely survives pressure on several at once. You do not have to choose one door: the same well-built file — the threat to the ancestral land, the irregular license, the biodiversity, the record of repression — can go to the courts, the environment office, the international networks, the investors, and the national public at once, and each front that opens makes the others harder to close. A Malagasy campaign's power comes not from any single lever but from pressing several together, with a united community and the world's scrutiny as the two that reach furthest past a captured state.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Malagasy and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the **community can stay united** against the promise of money, whether the protest can be **sustained**, whether the project threatens the **ancestral land, sacred sites, or unique habitat** in a way that rouses the nation, whether the **license was granted irregularly**, and whether **national and international allies** can be drawn in. Where a united, sustained protest meets a threat to the ancestral land and national attention, Madagascar's levers are formidable, as Soamahamanina showed; where a community is divided by poverty and the state is set on the project, discount the figures sharply.

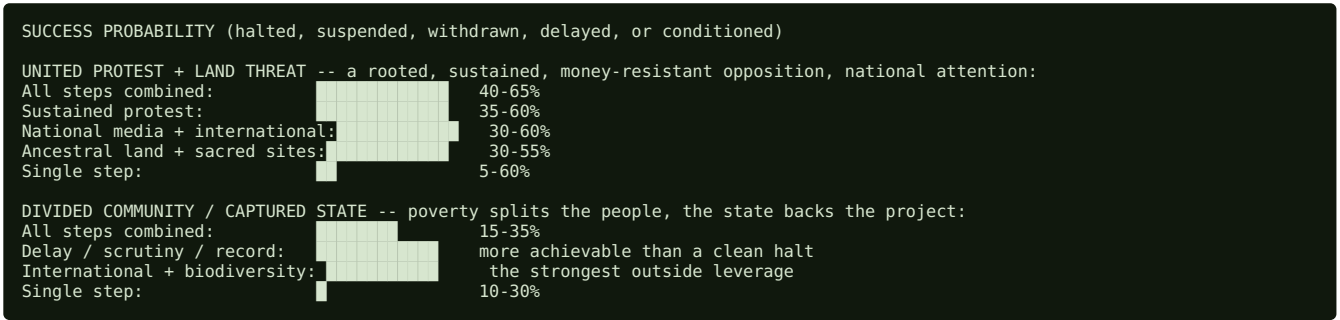
Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	1-3 months	low	Basis for every other step
Ancestral-land & sacred-site argument	30-55%	ongoing	low	A rooted, money-resistant opposition
Sustained community protest	35-60%	ongoing	low	Halt, suspension, or withdrawal
Environmental-permit objection	15-40%	during review	low	On record; grounds; delay
Court challenge (license/permit)	20-45%	months-years	low-moderate	License or permit questioned or voided
Biodiversity & international appeal	25-50%	ongoing	low	World scrutiny; investor pressure
National media & campaign	35-60%	ongoing	low	The national argument won; a halt forced
Staying united against the money	decisive	ongoing	low	The precondition for every other lever
Against a divided community or captured state	10-30%	years	low-moderate	Delay, scrutiny, partial gains
All steps combined (united protest + land threat)	40-65%	1-4 years	low-moderate	Halted, suspended, withdrawn, or delayed
All steps combined (poverty-divided community)	15-35%	1-4 years	low-moderate	Delayed, scrutinised; record built

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Madagascar's real strengths are distinctive — **sustained protest**, the **ancestral-land and tombs attachment**, the **fady and sacred sites**, the **unique biodiversity**, and **national and international allies**. Its constraints are severe and specific: **poverty and the promise of money that divides communities**, a **weak and often captured state**, **repression of defenders**, and wins that are often **suspensions to be defended**.

A note on cost: the ancestral-land argument, the protest, and the environmental objection cost little but courage and organisation. A court case and an international appeal cost more but are within reach with the conservation and human-rights networks. The expenditure that most changes outcomes is not money at all — it is the patient building of a unity that the proponent's money cannot break, exactly what carried Soamahamanina.

Effectiveness Visualization



How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Madagascar are **the united, sustained protest, the ancestral-land attachment, and national and international attention**, amplified by the biodiversity argument and the courts. Soamahamanina shows the ceiling: a united farming town drove out a foreign miner and forced a government halt. But poverty shows the floor: where the promise of money divides a community and the state backs the project, even a determined opposition may win only delay. Most Malagasy fights sit between these poles, and the honest lesson is that unity, the ancestral land, and outside attention are real and distinctive levers — decisive when the community holds together against the money, far weaker when it does not. Use the table to plan, not to predict: it tells you which combinations have historically done the most work and where to put scarce effort first. The single most important reading is that unity is not one lever among several but the precondition for all of them — a divided community cannot sustain a protest, cannot speak with one voice to the nation or the world, and hands the proponent exactly the split it seeks; so the effort spent holding the community together is never spent at the expense of the campaign, it is the campaign.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **Staying united against the money** — the precondition for everything in Madagascar; a community the proponent cannot divide with jobs and payments is one that can win.
2. **Sustained community protest** — the decisive lever; disciplined, week-after-week protest that forces a halt or a withdrawal, as at Soamahamanina.
3. **The ancestral land and sacred sites** — the roots that make the opposition deep and money-resistant, and rouse the wider nation.
4. **National and international attention** — the media, the conservation and human-rights networks, and the biodiversity argument that reach the government, the investors, and the world.
5. **The courts and the license defect** — the legal challenge to an irregular license or permit, and the record that outlasts a single decision.

What Malagasy Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **Unity is everything** — a community that holds together against the money can win; a divided one rarely does. **Sustained protest forces halts** — Soamahamanina and Base Toliara were halted by it. **The ancestral land roots the fight** — it is deeper than economics. **International attention bites** — the world watches Madagascar's nature and its defenders. **But poverty, repression, and a captured state are severe** — and wins are often suspensions. The through-line: **root the fight in the ancestral land and the sacred sites; build and hold a unity the money cannot break; sustain the protest; draw national and international attention through the biodiversity and human-rights arguments; challenge an irregular license; and defend a suspension, because in Madagascar a halt is rarely the end.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact decision that governs the project — and its weakest point. Vague opposition goes nowhere; opposition to "the forty-year gold license granted over the ancestral farmland of a whole commune, that would ruin the rice fields and the tombs" is a case — the case that drove the miner out of

Soamahamanina. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. What does it do to the ancestral land, the farms, and the sacred and unique places? This is the first Malagasy question, because the threat to the **tanindrazana, the tombs, the rice fields, the water, the sacred sites, and the unique habitat** is both the gravest harm and the argument that roots a resistance money cannot buy. In Malagasy culture the tie to ancestral land runs through the **razana**, the ancestors, whose tombs are often more elaborately built and more carefully tended than the houses of the living, and whose presence makes the land not a commodity but a trust held for the dead and the unborn. To lose ancestral land to a mine is not, in this understanding, to sell an asset but to betray the ancestors — which is why the land argument reaches a depth that a wage cannot, and why it is the foundation on which a durable Malagasy opposition is built. Does it touch a **sacred site (fady)** or a **globally important habitat** that draws the nation and the world?

2. Can the community stay united — and how will the money try to divide it? This is the decisive Malagasy question. How will the proponent use **jobs, payments, and promises** to split the community, and can the unity be built and held against them? A campaign that has not planned for the money has not planned to win.

3. Is the license sound, or granted irregularly? Was the **mining license or permit** granted properly, or by a **coup or transitional government**, or in irregular or corrupt circumstances, as questions surrounded Base Toliara's? An irregular license is a legal and a political weakness.

4. Can it be made a national and international cause? Can the fight reach the **national public**, and the **international conservation and human-rights networks** — especially through the **biodiversity** and the **treatment of defenders**? In a weak state, this outside attention is often what moves a project.

5. Who decides, who benefits, and who is watching? Which officials and the government granted the license; who owns, funds, and profits from the proponent; which communities and ancestral lands are affected and whether they can hold united; and which conservation and human-rights networks, lawyers, courts, press, and the wider public can be engaged. This maps your levers and your audiences at once.

A Worked Example

Suppose a foreign company holds a license to mine on the ancestral farmland of a rural community, threatening the rice fields, the water, and the tombs, on a license some believe was granted irregularly, with the company already promising jobs and payments.

Working the five questions: the harm — **the threat to the ancestral land, the farms, and the tombs** — is the argument to root the resistance and rouse the nation. The decisive task is **unity**: how will the company's **money divide the community**, and how will you hold it together? Is the **license irregular** — a legal weakness? Can it be made a **national and international cause**, through the biodiversity and the defenders? And the deciders are the government, with the courts, the international networks, and the press as pressure points.

Within a weekend you have moved from "we oppose the mine" to a target list: root the fight in the ancestral land and the tombs; build and guard the unity against the money; sustain the protest; challenge the irregular license; draw national and international attention; document the harm; and prepare for repression. That is a campaign, not a complaint — and it draws directly on how Soamahamanina drove out its miner. Notice what the exercise did: it converted a diffuse fear into a short list of concrete, assignable tasks — root the fight in the land, build and guard the unity, sustain the protest, challenge the license, reach the world — each tied to a specific lever and each of which can begin today. That is the difference the five questions make, and in Madagascar the second of them, unity against the money, is the one that most often decides whether all the others come to anything.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on. A judge, an environment official, a journalist, an international network, and — decisively — the wider public all move on evidence, not indignation. And in a weak state where a company's word is often taken on trust, a well-documented case is your protection. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Official Record

Get the documents the decision rests on. Obtain the **mining license or permit**, the **environmental permit and impact study**, and any government decisions — and, critically, **how and by whom the license was granted**, because an irregular grant (by a coup or transitional government, or in suspect circumstances) is a real weakness. Use requests to the authorities for anything withheld; a refusal is itself documentable. The gap between what the paper claims — a lawful license, an adequate study, a benefit to the community — and what the law requires and the ground shows is where cases are won. Pay special attention to the provenance of the license, because in Madagascar it is so often the weak point: a grant made by a transitional or coup government, or rushed through in the confusion of a political transition, may be legally vulnerable and is always politically damaging, since it lets the community argue that the project never had the legitimate consent of a legitimate government. Read the license not only for what it permits but for the circumstances of its making.

Layer 2: The Ground Truth

Document the reality the paper hides, and put the **ancestral land and the unique nature** at the centre. Record the **land, the farms, the water, the tombs, and the sacred sites** — what will be lost, and what the tanindrazana means to the community. Document the **habitat and its biodiversity** — the forest, the species found nowhere else — with the help of conservation scientists, because Madagascar's unique nature is a worldwide argument. Record the **radioactive or contamination risk** where relevant, as with the uranium and thorium in mineral sands. Photograph and date the **site and the land**, and capture **before-and-after**. Record **testimony** from farmers, elders, and those who hold the ancestral and sacred knowledge of the place.

Layer 3: The Defects and the Dangers

Finally, document the failures and the dangers. Is the **license irregular** — granted by a coup government, or in suspect circumstances? Is the **environmental study deficient**, understating the harm to the land, the water, or the unique habitat? Does the project threaten a **sacred site or a protected species**? Is the **consultation absent or staged**? And — because it is central in Madagascar — document the **repression**: the arrests, the tear gas, the detention of leaders, which are themselves a powerful argument to the nation and the world, as the arrests at Soamahamanina and the "Toliara nine" became. Each defect and danger is a separate ground — for a challenge, an appeal, an international complaint, and the public campaign — and together they make a case that is hard to wave away. This is the layer that most often decides Malagasy fights, because here a project that looked lawful is revealed to rest on an irregular license, to threaten a sacred land and a unique nature, and to be defended by the arrest of those who object.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Malagasy cases, and where to obtain them. You will not need every item; you will need the few that expose your project's particular defect or danger.

The License, Permit, and Their Paper Trail

- **The mining license or permit** — the grant, its terms and area, and above all **how and by whom it was granted** (an irregular or coup-era grant is a real weakness).
- **The environmental permit and impact study** — read them critically for what they understate about the land, the water, the tombs, the habitat, and the radioactive risk.
- **The land and ancestral records** — the customary and ancestral tenure, and the tombs and sacred sites the project would touch.
- **The consultation record** — evidence of whether the community was genuinely consulted, or the process staged.
- **The proponent and its money** — the company, its owners and financiers, its buyers, and — crucially — how it is using jobs and payments in the community.

How to Get Them

License records are held by the mining administration and its registry; environmental records by the **National Environment Office (ONE)**; land and ancestral matters at the commune and through the community's own knowledge. Much is hard to obtain in a weak and sometimes opaque system, so lean on **allies who can reach the documents**: the national environmental and human-rights organisations, the international conservation networks, and sympathetic lawyers and journalists. Work with **conservation scientists** on the biodiversity, because their evidence carries worldwide weight, and with **elders and ancestral-knowledge holders** on the land and the sacred sites, because their testimony is the moral heart of the case. Move early: evidence gathered, and the community's unity built, before the license is entrenched

and the money has spread, is worth far more than the same effort later.

The Ground Evidence

- **The ancestral land and the tombs** — mapped and testified, showing what the tanindrazana and the graves mean to the community.
- **The farms and water** — the rice fields, the rivers, the wells, and what the project would do to the livelihood and the drinking supply.
- **Biodiversity and habitat evidence** — the forest, the endemic species, the unique nature, from conservation scientists — a worldwide argument.
- **Radioactivity and contamination data** — where relevant, as with the uranium and thorium in mineral sands.
- **Dated, geotagged photographs and video** of the land, the site, and any repression.
- **The record of repression** — arrests, tear gas, detentions — documented for the nation and the world.
- **Testimony** — from farmers, elders, ancestral-knowledge holders, and scientists.

Organise It So It Persuades

Keep a **master timeline** of the license, the permit, the consultation, the protest, and every arrest and incident — the spine of any challenge, appeal, or campaign. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced in seconds. And keep an **argument bank** (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a farmer, an elder, a lawyer, a scientist, a journalist, an international network, and a judge — and the wider public — all see the same clear picture fast, and it guards against the campaign's own worst enemy, a claim that cannot be sourced when the company's people challenge it. In a country where the world's attention can be decisive, the community with the better-kept file — above all the clearest evidence of the threat to the ancestral land and the unique nature, and of the repression — is very often the one that reaches the nation and the world.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO BUILD UNITY AND SUSTAIN THE PROTEST

Evidence and law do not stop projects on their own. Organised, united, sustained people do — and in Madagascar that is the whole story, and its hardest challenge. Soamahamanina was won because a farming town marched every Thursday for months and would not be divided or worn down. A Malagasy campaign's strength is the depth of its unity and the endurance of its protest, and its greatest enemy is the poverty that a company's money exploits to split the community.

Phase 1: The Core, the Land, and the Unity

Start with a small, committed core — five to fifteen people, including **elders and ancestral-knowledge holders** whose authority roots the fight — and build the campaign around the **ancestral land and the tombs**, because that is what makes an opposition deep and money-resistant. Assign roles: license and permit, documentation, legal liaison, ally and international liaison, media, and — above all — **unity and mobilisation**. Agree on the goal — the license cancelled, the project halted or suspended, the ancestral land protected — and on what you will and will not accept. And plan, from the first day, for how the **money will try to divide you**.

Phase 2: Building and Guarding the Unity

Then widen — but in Madagascar, the first task of widening is **guarding the unity**, because the proponent will use jobs, payments, and promises to split the community, as happened at Base Toliara. Bring in the **whole community** around the ancestral land and the tombs; the **neighbouring communities** who share the threat; the **national environmental and human-rights organisations**; the **conservation scientists and international networks**, whose interest in Madagascar's unique nature gives reach and protection; and the **churches and traditional authorities**, whose moral weight helps hold a community together. Name and counter the divisions openly: make the case that the money is temporary and the ancestral land is forever, and that a divided community loses while a united one wins. The Soamahamanina campaign held because its unity — rooted in the land and sustained week after week — was stronger than the inducements, and that unity is the thing a Malagasy campaign must build and guard above all. Practically, this means treating unity not as a happy by-product but as the campaign's central project: identifying early who is most vulnerable to the company's offers, bringing them into the fold with respect rather than suspicion, giving everyone a role and a stake, and using the moral authority of the elders and the churches to frame acceptance of the money as a betrayal of the ancestors and the community. The proponent will work every seam of poverty and grievance; the campaign's job is

to close them faster than the money can open them.

A worked coalition example. Facing a mine on ancestral land, the community and its elders form the rooted base; the ancestral-land and tomb attachment holds it together against the money; the national human-rights and environmental organisations bring capacity and protection; the conservation scientists and international networks bring the biodiversity argument and the world's eyes; and the churches and traditional authorities help keep the community one. No single group could have carried it; together they cover the roots, the unity, the law, and the national and international stage — the model that drove the miner from Soamahamanina.

Phase 3: Sustaining It Against Division and Repression

Campaigns in Madagascar die of two things: **division** and **exhaustion**, and both are actively engineered. Meet on a rhythm. Give people concrete, finishable tasks. Mark small wins — a strong protest, a court filing, an international statement, an arrested leader freed. Rotate roles. But above all, **hold the unity**: watch for the payments and promises that split communities, answer them openly, and keep the ancestral land at the centre, because it is the one argument money cannot outbid. Prepare, too, for **repression** — arrests, tear gas, detentions — and turn it into strength: the arrests at Soamahamanina and Toliara drew national and international attention and a UN rapporteur, and a community that documents and publicises repression makes its persecutors pay a price. A protest that stays united and endures, and turns repression into attention, is a project's worst enemy.

Phase 4: Showing Strength

Numbers and unity must be seen. Sustain the **disciplined, peaceful, regular protest** — the weekly march that showed Soamahamanina's resolve — and turn people out at every stage. Let the **elders, the ancestral-knowledge holders, and respected voices** speak, so the nation sees a community defending its sacred land, not a faction. Make the repression visible, and make the fight a national and international cause. The point is not spectacle; it is to demonstrate — to the government, the company, the courts, and the world — that the community is united, rooted, and will not be moved, exactly as Soamahamanina demonstrated until the government halted the mine and the company left.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES — THE MINING CODE, THE PERMIT, AND THE COURTS

Malagasy law gives communities some real tools, though in a weak state they work best alongside protest and international pressure. You do not need a final ruling to win with them: a challenge to an irregular license, an environmental objection, or an international appeal halts a project, forces disclosure, and creates leverage — though, as Soamahamanina showed, the decisive blow often comes from sustained protest and national attention. Engage lawyers and the human-rights organisations early — but understand the tools yourself.

The License and Its Irregularity

The first lever is the **license itself**. Was it granted properly, or **irregularly** — by a coup or transitional government, or in suspect or corrupt circumstances, as questions surrounded Base Toliara's coup-era license? An irregular license is both a legal ground to challenge the project and a powerful public argument that it never had legitimate authority. Establish early how the license was granted, because a flaw there can undo the whole project.

The Environmental Permit

The second lever is the **environmental permit**. Significant projects need a permit and impact study through the **National Environment Office**, in principle with public consultation. A deficient study — understating the harm to the land, the water, the sacred sites, or a protected species — or an absent or staged consultation is a ground to demand refusal or to challenge the permit. Enforcement is weak, so pair this with protest and outside attention, but the record you build here matters.

The Courts and Human Rights

The third lever is the **courts and the human-rights framework**. Madagascar's courts can, in principle, review the legality of licenses and permits, though the system is weak and can be captured. More powerfully, the **repression of defenders** — the arrests, the detentions — engages **national and international human-rights** mechanisms, as the

Soamahamanina arrests drew a UN rapporteur and the "Toliara nine" drew national outcry. Turning repression into a human-rights case both protects your leaders and shames the project.

International and Financier Pressure

Finally, a distinctively powerful Malagasy lever: **international attention and financier pressure**. Madagascar's unique biodiversity gives a threatened habitat a worldwide constituency, and global conservation and human-rights networks, and the investors and buyers of a project, can be reached and pressed in ways a weak domestic system cannot match. Where the courts are weak, the world's scrutiny — of the nature at stake and the defenders at risk — is often the strongest lever a community holds. Madagascar occupies a singular place in the world's conservation imagination: an island where the great majority of species exist nowhere else, home to the lemurs and the baobabs, so that the loss of a forest here is felt as a loss to the whole planet. That gives a Malagasy community a constituency and a set of allies far larger than its own numbers — international organisations, scientists, and donors who can bring pressure to bear on a government and a company that a poor rural community, acting alone, never could.

Where to Turn and With Whom

License challenges and human-rights matters go to the **courts** and, for repression, the **national and international human-rights mechanisms**; environmental objections to the **National Environment Office**; and international appeals to the **conservation and human-rights networks and the financiers**. Get help early: Madagascar's human-rights and environmental organisations and their international allies know these procedures, the weaknesses of the system, and the strongest ground, and can protect defenders and reach the world. Help engaged while the license is contestable, and before repression isolates the leaders, is worth far more than help sought after the doors have closed — and in Madagascar, the strongest strategy marries the legal and international levers to a united, sustained protest.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a judge, an environment official, an international network, a journalist, and your own community in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each audience is what lets a campaign reach every lever at once.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a mine would destroy the ancestral farmland and tombs of a community and a habitat found nowhere else, on a license granted by a coup government. That one fact becomes:

- **An ancestral-land argument (to the community):** this is the tanindrazana, the land of our ancestors and their tombs, and no money can replace it — the argument that holds a community united.
- **A legal argument:** the license was granted irregularly, by a coup government, and the environmental study is deficient — grounds to challenge it.
- **A biodiversity argument (to the world):** the project would destroy a habitat and species found nowhere else on Earth — the argument that draws the world.
- **A human-rights argument:** the defenders of this land have been arrested and gassed — the argument that engages the international mechanisms and shames the project.
- **A media argument:** a foreign company destroying a sacred land and a unique nature, and jailing those who object — a vivid, resonant story.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in Madagascar the arguments that most often decide things are the **ancestral-land** one, because it holds the community united, and the **biodiversity-and-human-rights** one, because it draws the national and international attention a weak state responds to. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a journalist can be backed in the file and a claim made to your community can be proven by the elders and the scientists; consistency across audiences is itself persuasive.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The courts and the environment authorities want the illegality framed precisely against the specific rule — the irregular license, the deficient study, the human-rights breach — with the documents, the science, and the timeline that prove it.

Your own community needs the ancestral-land argument above all — the tanindrazana, the tombs, the land that is forever against money that is temporary — because unity is the precondition for everything. This is the argument to make most often and most carefully, in the words and through the authorities the community trusts — the elders, the ancestral-knowledge holders, the churches — because it is aimed not at persuading outsiders but at holding the community itself against the steady pressure of the company's offers. Every other argument in the campaign depends on this one landing: a community convinced that the land is worth more than the money is a community that can do everything else.

Journalists need a specific, verified, human story with a hook: a named community and sacred land, a documented threat, arrests, and a live decision.

The international networks and investors respond to the biodiversity at stake and the treatment of defenders — the two things about Madagascar the world most readily takes up.

The government, in the end, responds to the pressure all of these create — the united community, the national outcry, the world's scrutiny — as it responded at Soamahamanina.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Media is not vanity; it is a lever — and in a weak state, where domestic institutions are often captured, national and international attention is frequently *the* lever. Coverage raises the political cost of a project, reaches the government over the heads of captured local authorities, draws the world to Madagascar's unique nature and its defenders, and protects a community by making its fight visible. Soamahamanina was, in the end, won through attention: the weekly protests, the arrests, and the UN rapporteur's notice made the mine a national and international embarrassment the government chose to halt.

Build the Story

Reporters and the public need specifics: a named place and stake, a documented threat, and a live decision. "A project threatens the environment" is not a story; "a foreign company would destroy the ancestral farmland and tombs of a whole commune, and a habitat found nowhere else, and has jailed those who object" is. Lead with your strongest verified facts — the ancestral land, the unique nature, and the repression — and offer a human story: a farmer, an elder, an arrested leader. In Madagascar the story of a community defending its sacred land and a unique nature against a foreign company, and being repressed for it, is uniquely powerful at home and abroad.

Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings. **Local and community voices** first. Then the **national outlets** — Madagascar's press and radio — which carry the story to the whole nation and the government; in a fight decided at the national level, this ring is essential. Then, crucially, the **international networks and media** — the global conservation organisations drawn by Madagascar's unique nature, and the human-rights networks drawn by the treatment of defenders — which bring a scrutiny and a reach a weak domestic system cannot match, and which reach the project's international investors and buyers. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. In Madagascar the **international ring is unusually powerful**, because the world cares about this island's nature and its defenders. The domestic and international rings work best together: national coverage builds the pressure the government feels most directly and protects defenders by making their treatment visible at home, while international coverage brings the scrutiny of donors, conservation bodies, and investors that a weak or captured domestic system cannot deflect. A story that travels from a Malagasy radio station to a global conservation network and back again carries a weight that neither could give it alone.

Sustain It, and Keep It True

A single article changes little; a drumbeat changes decisions. Plan a sequence — the ancestral land, the biodiversity, the irregular license, the repression — so there is always a next hook, and document everything so the story can be told and defended. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and consistent; a single exaggeration handed to the company can cost credibility, especially with international allies who must vouch for you. And keep telling the story **after a halt or suspension**, because in Madagascar a project fights to revive itself. Verified, specific, ancestral-land-and-biodiversity-centred, and relentless — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes here, and that turned a farming town's protest into a national and international cause the government could not ignore.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you object, demand, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act — including, crucially in Madagascar, the international networks beyond a captured domestic system. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the ancestral land, the unique nature, and the law.

8A. Environmental Objection

To: the National Environment Office (ONE) **Subject:** Objection — environmental permit, [project] at [location]

As a community/person affected by [project] at [location], we object to its environmental permit. Our grounds, with evidence: (1) it would destroy [the ancestral farmland / the water / a sacred site]; (2) it threatens [a habitat and species found nowhere else]; (3) [it risks radioactive contamination, as with the uranium and thorium in mineral sands]; (4) the study is deficient and the consultation was absent or staged. We attach our evidence. We request that the permit be **refused**, and that our objection be formally answered.

8B. Challenge to an Irregular License

To: the mining administration / the government / the courts (via counsel) **Subject:** The license for [project] was granted irregularly

We submit that the mining license for [project] at [location] was granted **irregularly** — [by a coup or transitional government / in suspect circumstances / over ancestral land without consent]. We attach the record. We ask that the license be **reviewed and cancelled**, as its legitimacy is in question, and that the project not proceed on an unlawful grant.

8C. Appeal to International Conservation / Human-Rights Networks

To: [a global conservation organisation / a human-rights network] **Subject:** Threat to [unique habitat] and to defenders — [project], Madagascar

We write regarding [project] at [location], which threatens [a habitat and species found nowhere else on Earth / a sacred ancestral land], and whose defenders have been **[arrested / gassed / detained]**. We attach our evidence, including the biodiversity at stake and the repression. We ask you to bring your scrutiny and your networks to bear — with the government, the investors, and the world — as such attention helped halt the mine at Soamahamania.

8D. Instructing a Lawyer / Human-Rights Organisation

To: a lawyer / a human-rights or environmental organisation **Subject:** [Project] — legal options and protection for defenders

We believe [project] is unlawful and damaging because [the license was granted irregularly / the study is deficient / it destroys ancestral land / defenders have been arrested]. We attach the license, the study, our evidence, and the record of repression, and seek advice on **challenging the license**, an **environmental objection**, and **protecting our detained leaders** through the human-rights mechanisms. We also seek help reaching the international networks and the investors.

8E. Letter to an Investor / Financier / Buyer

To: [the investor / parent company / financier / buyer] **Subject:** [Project] — legal, reputational, and human-rights risk

We write regarding your [investment in / financing of / purchasing from] [company] in connection with [project] at [location]. The project [one-line stake — e.g. "would destroy the ancestral land of a whole community and a habitat found nowhere on Earth"], its license [was granted irregularly], and its defenders have been **[arrested]**. We remind you that Malagasy communities have driven out a foreign miner and forced the suspension of a major mine through united protest and international attention. We ask you to weigh the legal, reputational, and human-rights risk, and we are glad to share our evidence.

8F. Letter to the National Government

To: [the relevant ministry / the government] **Subject:** [Project] at [location] — request to halt and protect our land

We are the community of [place], writing about [project], which threatens our **ancestral land, our tombs, our farms, and a unique nature**. We ask the government to **halt or suspend** the project and protect our land and our people, as it halted the mine at Soamahamanina and suspended Base Toliara. We attach our evidence and the record of the harm and the repression, and we welcome the chance to be heard.

8G. Email to a Reporter (National or International)

To: [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — [the community / the land / the defenders]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have something your readers should know, with a clear hook: [documents and evidence] show [quantified finding — e.g. "a foreign company would destroy the ancestral land of a whole commune and a habitat found nowhere on Earth, and has jailed those who object"], with [a decision] due [date]. It echoes how Soamahamanina drove out its miner. I can share the full file and connect you with farmers, an elder, and a scientist. Could we talk this week?

8H. Community Statement / Petition

To: the government and the public (as a statement or petition) **Subject:** We will not give up our ancestral land to [project]

We, the community of [place] and citizens of Madagascar, refuse to surrender our **ancestral land, our tombs, and our unique nature** to [project]. This land is the tanindrazana, the land of our ancestors, and no money can replace it. We call on the government to halt the project and on all Malagasy and the world to stand with us — as the people of Soamahamanina stood, and won.

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable where you can, and log every one, along with every arrest and incident, in your timeline — the record of an objection, an irregular license, and repression is itself evidence, and exactly what the courts, the international networks, and the press will heed. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the ancestral land, the unique nature, and the law; attach your evidence; and route them, where you can, through the human-rights and conservation organisations, your lawyers, the international networks, and the national and international press. The reply, or the decision, becomes part of your record, and in Madagascar that record feeds the levers that matter most: the united community, the sustained protest, the ancestral land, and national and international attention.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a long campaign. With a few hours a week you can still do real damage to a bad project. In rough order of impact for the effort:

- 1. Root the fight in the ancestral land — and build unity.** In Madagascar, the tanindrazana and the tombs hold a community together against the money, and unity is everything. Make the land the centre, and plan against the division the money will bring (8H).
- 2. Sustain the protest.** Disciplined, peaceful, regular protest is the decisive lever, as the weekly marches at Soamahamanina showed. Keep it going.
- 3. Reach the international networks.** An appeal to the global conservation and human-rights networks (8C) brings the world's scrutiny — the strongest lever in a weak state — through the biodiversity and the defenders.
- 4. Challenge an irregular license.** If the license was granted by a coup government or irregularly (8B), that is a real legal and public weakness.
- 5. Object on the environment and the sacred sites.** An objection to the environment office (8A) puts the harm to the land, water, and unique habitat on record.
- 6. Document and publicise repression.** Every arrest and tear-gassing (8C, 8G), documented and told, draws attention and protects your leaders.
- 7. Reach the national and international press.** A vivid ancestral-land-and-biodiversity story (8G) carries the fight to the nation and the world.

Do only the first three and you will have rooted the fight, built unity, sustained the protest, and drawn the world's attention — the exact foundation on which Soamahamanina won. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: root it in the ancestral land and unity, sustain the protest, reach the international networks. Those three moves are exactly the ones that, done from the start, put the decisive Malagasy levers into play — a community the money cannot divide, a protest that will not fade, and the scrutiny of a world that treasures this island's nature — and they are within reach of a determined community with its elders, its resolve, and a few letters to the right allies.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Madagascar's system is tilted steeply, and you must understand how, so you neither waste effort nor miss the levers that work.

Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt here is severe, and honesty demands naming it. The deepest is **poverty**: in one of the world's poorest countries, a company's promise of **jobs and money is a weapon that divides communities**, and a family with nothing may genuinely want the mine. The **state is weak, unstable, and often captured** — licenses have been granted by coup governments, corruption is real, local authorities are courted, and the rule of law is thin and unreliable. **Defenders are repressed** — arrested, gassed, detained, as at Soamahamanina and Toliara. **Enforcement is weak**, so even a legal win may not be honoured. And wins are often **suspensions the company fights to reverse**, not permanent cancellations. Where these tilts bite, the domestic system gives little — but real levers still reach past it.

What Still Works — And Some Is Distinctive

The decisive point is that even where the system tilts steeply, real and distinctive levers remain.

A united community still cannot be ignored. Soamahamanina proved that a community the money cannot divide, protesting week after week, can force a halt and a withdrawal — the one thing no inducement overcomes.

The ancestral land still binds. The tanindrazana and the tombs are a claim deeper than economics, and the root of a unity that holds.

The world still watches. Madagascar's unique nature and the treatment of its defenders draw international scrutiny that reaches the government and the investors over the head of a captured system.

Repression still backfires. Every arrest, documented and publicised, draws attention and shames the project, as the Soamahamanina arrests drew a UN rapporteur.

The record and the roots endure. What you document and the unity you build outlast a single decision and can win the next round — and defend a suspension.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for Madagascar is hard, and this guide will not pretend otherwise. Poverty, a captured state, and repression are severe obstacles, and a divided community rarely wins. But a **united community, rooted in its ancestral land and sustaining its protest, and drawing national and international attention, can force a halt or a suspension**, as Soamahamanina and Base Toliara showed. So diagnose your fight honestly: root it in the **ancestral land**; build and guard the **unity** against the money above all else; sustain the **protest**; draw the **world's attention** through the biodiversity and the defenders; challenge an **irregular license**; and **defend a suspension**, because the project will fight to revive. Where a community is divided and the state set on the project, aim at delay, scrutiny, and the record — and remember that a united Malagasy community has driven out a foreign miner and stopped a mine the government backed.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

In Madagascar, corruption is not the exception but often the terrain, so this section is central. When a project advances through undue influence — a license granted by a coup government or bought, an environmental permit waved through,

local authorities and even community members paid to support it, a process bent toward a company and away from the people — you stop trying to persuade a captured decision-maker and start exposing and going around them.

How to Tell

Look for the signatures of capture, which in Madagascar are common. A **license granted by a coup or transitional government**, or in suspect circumstances, as questions surrounded Base Toliara's; **local authorities and mayors aligned with the project** and its money; **community members paid** to support it and divide the opposition; an **environmental permit granted despite obvious harm**; and **repression** of those who object. Trace the money: who benefits, and who in power or in the community is being paid. One anomaly may be error; in Madagascar, a pattern of paid support, an irregular license, and repression is capture, and should be assumed possible until the process proves itself clean.

Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where undue influence reaches. **Local authorities, officials, parts of the courts, and even some community members** can be bought or aligned. But even in Madagascar, some bodies and audiences are far harder to capture: the **international conservation and human-rights networks**, beyond any local interest; the **international press and the project's own investors and buyers**, who fear reputational and legal risk; the **elders and ancestral-knowledge holders**, whose authority rests on the land, not money; and — decisively — a **community united around its ancestral land**, which no payment can fully divide. Capture thrives on the paid split and the quiet grant; your task is to hold the unity, expose the corruption, and lift the matter to the world.

What to Do

Do not confront and tip off a captured decision-maker. Instead, **hold your unity and document the anomaly** — the irregular license, the paid authorities, the bought supporters, the waved-through permit, the repression — and take it to the audiences beyond its control: the **international conservation and human-rights networks**, the **international press and the investors**, and the **national public**. Pair the exposure with the ancestral-land and biodiversity case, so the corruption and the harm surface together. And guard the community's unity above all, because in Madagascar corruption's chief weapon is division: a company that cannot split the community with its money is a company that must fight in the open, where the ancestral land, the unique nature, and the world's scrutiny are against it.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps win when they run together. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight — which in Madagascar turns first and last on the community's unity, and on the national and international attention a weak state responds to.

Early (Weeks 0-8): The Ancestral Land, the Unity, the Protest

Pin down the project, the license, and — first — what it does to the **ancestral land, the farms, the tombs, and the unique nature** (Step 1). Build the **core and the unity** around the land, with the elders (Step 3). Move at once on what is decisive: **root the fight in the ancestral land and begin building the unity** against the money (8H); **start the sustained protest; appeal to the international networks** through the biodiversity and any repression (8C); and **object on the environment and challenge an irregular license** (8A, 8B). Begin **documenting** the harm and the repression (Step 2). Reach a **lawyer and the human-rights organisations** early (8D). This phase lays the foundation, and in Madagascar the unity and the attention begun here are what ultimately win.

Middle (Months 2-24): Escalate on Every Front, Hold the Unity

Widen the coalition while **guarding the unity** against the money (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience (Turning Evidence). Escalate as the facts warrant — the **license challenge**, the **environmental objection**, the **human-rights case** for repressed defenders, and the **international and investor appeals** (Step 4). Build the media drumbeat from local to national to international (Step 5). Each front feeds the others. Do the time-critical things first — sustain the protest, protect the leaders, keep the unity — because a broken unity is the one loss that cannot be undone. And sequence the rest so each lands when it bites hardest — the international appeal timed to a moment of repression the world will notice, the license challenge readied when a change of government reopens the question of its legitimacy, the investor letter sent when the company is seeking finance — because in Madagascar a fight is won by those who hold their unity, endure, and use the world's attention at the points where a captured state is most exposed.

Later (Months 6-48+): The Halt, and Defending It

Sustain the unity and the protest and the attention; keep the record alive. Pursue what is achievable — the license **cancelled, the project halted or suspended, the ancestral land protected** — and, against a divided community or a captured state, the **delay, scrutiny, and record** that are the realistic gains. And — distinctively in Madagascar — **defend the win**: a suspension is not a cancellation, and the company will fight to revive it, as Base Toliara did, so keep the unity and the attention alive after the halt. Judge success honestly. Sometimes it is a miner driven out and a mine halted, as at Soamahamanina. Sometimes it is a project suspended, scrutinised, and delayed while the community holds. Both are victories worth the fight.

The Shape of a Campaign

WEEKS 0-8 Ancestral land + build unity | Start the protest | Appeal to international networks | Object + challenge the license
MONTHS 2-24 Widen + GUARD the unity | Arguments | License + environment + human rights + investors | National & international media
MONTHS 6-48+ The halt / suspension | Win a cancel / halt / delay | DEFEND it, keep the unity, guard the land

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Madagascar gives communities real and distinctive strengths, and also confronts them with some of the severest obstacles in this guide, and the honest measure of it is how squarely it faces both.

The strengths are real and distinctive. **Sustained community protest** is Madagascar's decisive lever — the force that drove a foreign miner out of Soamahamanina and suspended a mine at Toliara. The **ancestral land, the tanindrazana, and the tombs** root a resistance deeper than economics and harder for money to divide. The **fady and sacred sites** protect some places by tradition. And the **globally unique biodiversity** gives a threatened habitat a worldwide constituency and powerful international allies, whose scrutiny reaches a weak state and its investors. These are the levers that let a farming town defeat a mining company.

The limits are just as real, and this guide names them plainly because in Madagascar they are grave. **Poverty and the promise of money divide communities**, and are the proponent's sharpest weapon. The **state is weak, unstable, and often captured. Defenders are arrested, gassed, and detained.** And wins are often **suspensions the company fights to reverse**. No guide should pretend these away; in Madagascar, the fight is above all a fight to stay united.

So the realistic promise is this: **root the fight in the ancestral land; build and guard a unity the money cannot break; sustain the protest; draw national and international attention through the biodiversity and the defenders; challenge an irregular license; and defend a suspension — running all of it together.** Do that, and against a project your community can unite against, you can drive out the miner and force a halt, as Soamahamanina did; against a divided community or a captured state, you can delay, scrutinise, and build the record and the attention that win the next round. Do it as the people of Soamahamanina did — a farming town that marched every Thursday, held its unity against the money and the tear gas, and would not give up its ancestral land.

A last word on unity and endurance. Madagascar's great lesson is that a united community, rooted in its ancestral land, can drive out a foreign mining company and force its own government to stop a mine — and that the one thing that can defeat it is division, engineered by a proponent's money in a land of great poverty. The company counts on that poverty, on splitting the community, on repression, and on the long wait wearing you down. Its advantage is money, and the desperation it can exploit. Yours is the deepest advantage a community can have — an ancestral land that money cannot replace, a unity rooted in the tombs of your ancestors, a unique nature the world will defend, and the proven power of a protest that will not stop. Play to that. Keep the file and the record of repression, keep the ancestral land at the centre, keep the unity above all else, sustain the protest, draw the world's eyes, and treat every march, every international appeal, every irregular license exposed, and every day the community holds together as a brick in a wall no company's money can climb — and that a united community can hold against every attempt to revive the project.

The tools are here, and Madagascar itself proved them: a farming town, with nothing but its unity and its refusal, drove out a foreign gold company and forced its own government to halt the mine. What decides the outcome, in the end, is method, endurance, and a community united around the land of its ancestors — and those you supply, as the rice farmers of Soamahamanina supplied them, Thursday after Thursday, until the miner was gone. Begin today, begin with the ancestral land and the unity that protects it, and build from there. Communities before you have driven out, halted, and suspended what looked unstoppable — a foreign miner driven from the valley, a government-backed mine halted, an ancestral land defended by the very people whose ancestors lie buried in it. What was won at Soamahamanina — by rice farmers who marched every Thursday, held their unity against the money and the tear gas, and drew the eyes of the nation and the world to their ancestral land — can be won again by any community that roots its fight in the land of its ancestors, refuses

to be divided, and will not stop. What was won at Soamahamanina can be won again. So can yours.